Nature of the request

An eligible institution, still to be confirmed, would request **$25,920 in Exhibitions: Planning** support for a temporary, single-site exhibition, Records, Memory, and Civilian Violence: The Horner Family in Civil War Arkansas. This 12-month planning project would develop and test a source-based exhibition concept for general public audiences in Johnson County, Arkansas. Its central question is how government records, memorials and later family narratives illuminate different parts of civilian wartime experience. The intended products are a scholarly interpretive framework, a checked object/source list, accessible sample labels, a design concept, an audience-testing report and a costed implementation plan. This is an institutional discussion draft, not a completed application.[1]

Humanities content

The project would examine three related ideas. First, government records describe people through administrative purposes: a land patent records a transfer of specified tracts, while a census reports household and property information. The corrected 1860 Mulberry Township image lists Spencer Horner and Permelia; the 1857 patent lists four tracts. Neither explains the later attackers' motives. Displaying record and inference side by side would help visitors practice close reading rather than mistake property valuations for evidence of intent.

Second, memories of violence develop through family transmission and public commemoration. A marker reading gives William Riley Horner's death as 10 August 1864 and attributes responsibility to parties known to his family. A later account attributed to 1942 describes an attack and reprisals. Visitors would ask what each source preserves, when it was made, and which questions remain beyond it. The project would neither present a reprisal count as a proved casualty total nor infer official refusal to investigate from missing records.

Third, uncertainty can be made legible without abandoning historical interpretation. The archive's prior census misidentification and reversed patent aliquot demonstrate why provenance and correction matter. A label could show a claim being narrowed as a source is checked. The exhibition would connect this local example to the broader history of irregular warfare and civilian protection. Proposed contextual reading includes Daniel E. Sutherland's A Savage Conflict (2009) and Thomas A. DeBlack's With Fire and Sword (2003). Publisher listings were checked, but full texts and relevant page-level arguments have not been integrated in this draft. Appointed outside scholars must develop and document that contextual argument before submission. No scholarly endorsement is claimed.

Project formats

The envisioned exhibition would have four compact sections: household and land; wartime loss; family memory and memorials; and the historian’s evidence desk. A census facsimile with a readable partial transcription would introduce administrative evidence. A patent detail would let visitors compare the four tract descriptions without suggesting a verified modern house site. A short, attributed family-account paraphrase and a permitted marker image would invite comparison of document dates, event dates and memorial dates. The evidence desk would ask visitors to choose a next record and explain what it could resolve.

Large-print labels, image descriptions, seated reading access and a printable text companion would be tested during planning. No graphic injury detail is necessary to the interpretive questions. Visitors could engage the land/census comparison independently of the killing narrative. A modest website companion and educator sheets would extend access to the public exhibition; an online archive or school lesson alone is not the proposed NEH primary format. Exact venue, available floor area, objects and installation dates await institutional decisions and are not invented here. Planning would develop, rather than claim completion of, a final exhibition.

Project resources

The existing archive contains a patent image, a corrected census household image, compared-copy GLO survey notes, a marker photograph, a pension payment ledger, published family-account excerpts and research summaries. The v21 source catalog distinguishes examined images from unverified original-record claims. It also corrects a mislabeled cemetery gallery and withdraws unsupported modern parcel conclusions. These resources provide a starting collection for interpretation, not a fully authenticated exhibition object list.

For each proposed object, the institution would record custody, original collection and identifier, date, maker, reliable transcription, rights, display format and relevance to a label. Federal record images and privately made photographs would receive separate rights assessments. A marker image or family manuscript would enter exhibition production only after permission or an appropriate rights determination. Missing originals would be sought only where needed for the exhibition’s interpretive questions. The plan does not fund an open-ended genealogy search or certify the original service and pension files through summaries.

Project history

Daniel Bret Lingar has assembled a descendant-led website and dossier about the Horner family. On 17 October 2026, a source and funding review identified image substitutions, unsupported source-to-claim links, spatial conflicts and overly broad grant language. This planning draft builds on a new concise reading edition, source catalog and correction register. It does not bill the already prepared website or bibliography as future initial creation. Proposed new work is

independent scholarly interpretation, provenance and rights completion for selected objects, audience testing, accessible design and an implementation plan. A comparison with existing local exhibitions and collections is still required; priority or uniqueness is not asserted.

Audience, marketing, and promotion

The proposed primary audience is the general public in Johnson County, including adults interested in regional history and visitors who may not pursue genealogy. No audience survey, attendance history, mailing-list size, venue commitment or partner reach is established in this draft. A provisional planning target is two small prototype sessions totaling 20–30 adult participants, with recruitment and capacity to be agreed by the institutional host. This is an estimated testing sample, not an exhibition attendance forecast. The institution would document recruitment channels, accessibility requests and attendance without presuming a demographic profile. Any later public attendance estimate must derive from the confirmed venue’s actual comparable-program records. Schools are a companion audience, not the basis of the proposed NEH public-format eligibility.

Project evaluation

Prototype visitors would compare two sources, distinguish a directly stated fact from an inference, and identify a useful next record. The evaluation consultant would gather anonymous responses, observe confusing labels and record image-reading or access barriers. A proposed design target is that at least 75% of responding visitors can correctly distinguish the 10 August death inscription from the separate attack-date claim after using the display. This is not a measured result. The evaluation report would include participant count, response count, question wording, anonymized totals, limitations and the revisions made. Small convenience samples would inform design rather than support population-wide claims. No personal trauma disclosure or student information is required.

Organizational profile

Required completion before submission: identify the eligible applicant by legal name, status, mission, location, annual operating budget, staff capacity and relevant public audience/visitor figures, with documentary support. No institution is named as a committed applicant. The recipient must own the project substantively through decisions, collections/permissions management, scholarly direction, public access and financial administration. The 2026 NEH notice excludes individuals and for-profit applicants and disallows a fiscal sponsor applying on behalf of an ineligible organization. A pass-through arrangement for Daniel Lingar or Capitol Contracts LLC would not solve eligibility. Each collaborating organization must supply a confirmed role and authorized commitment; no implied endorsement should be inferred from a prospect list.

Project team

The proposed roles are an applicant project director, a source researcher/descendant collaborator, a coordinator, an exhibition designer, an accessibility reviewer and an evaluation consultant. Daniel Lingar is proposed for the source-research role, subject to an approved scope and written institutional relationship; his descendant perspective does not substitute for independent historical review. No person’s credentials, résumé, available hours or agreement is invented. The applicant must name qualified staff, document their responsibilities and approve procurement or contracting arrangements before submission. Proposed labor quantities and rates remain estimates.

Humanities scholars and consultants

Two outside historians are proposed: one with Arkansas Civil War/irregular warfare expertise and one with public history, memory or documentary interpretation expertise. Each would be involved across source selection, interpretive framing, label review, prototype discussion and final planning review, with 40 estimated hours per scholar. An education consultant would review the companion source sheets. The institution must recruit named qualified advisers, consult their work and obtain signed, dated letters describing scope, availability and agreed compensation before applying. No scholar has accepted this role in this draft. The bibliography is a proposed reading framework, not evidence of those consultations.

[1] This draft contains AI-generated text prepared with ChatGPT/Codex and requires human source checking, revision and institutional approval. Retain an appropriate acknowledgment for any AI-generated text used in an NEH proposal, as required by the 2026 notice. The applicant must replace all unconfirmed organizational, team, rights, audience and cost assumptions before submission.